

Any reduction in rate is better than staying where it was before you made a simple phone call. Let's use Rhoda as an example. These days, when calling your credit card, your first lesson in patience is punching in enough numbers to get a real person on the line.

Credit Card Company: Thank you for calling Outrageous Credit Card Company; this is customer service. How can I help you today?

Rhoda: I'd like to find out my interest rate on my account.

CCC: Yes, ma'am.

Rhoda: Can you tell me what interest rate I'm paying right now?

CCC: Yes, ma'am. That would be a rate of 22%.

Rhoda: That is rather steep. I would like to request that my rate be lowered. Can you do that or do I need to talk to somebody else?

CCC: Yes, ma'am. I can lower the rate to 19% for you today.

Rhoda: 19%, is that the best you can do? I really need for a lower rate.

CCC: Yes, ma'am. Let's see. I can lower that rate to 17% today.

Rhoda: I was really hoping for better than that. I have an offer from Carefree Credit right now for 0% APR for balance transfers. Is there a promotion you are having right now for 0%?

CCC: No, ma'am.

Rhoda: If you can't give me better than 17%, I need to talk to a supervisor or a manager or somebody who has that authority.

CCC: Yes, ma'am. Please hold.

Rhoda stayed cool and patient, no matter how times she heard "yes ma'am," and after a few minutes a supervisor came on the line and asked what she could do for Rhoda.

Rhoda: I've been a customer for a long time and I usually pay my bill on time, but right now things have gotten tight and